

UNIQUE Function in Excel

1. What is UNIQUE?

The UNIQUE function takes a list and returns each different value only once, removing the repeats. It solves the problem of long columns where the same item appears many times, such as product categories, regions, or customers. A Data Analyst uses it to get a clean list of distinct items without changing the original data.

2. Syntax

`=UNIQUE(array, [by_col], [exactly_once])`

Argument	Required?	What it accepts
array	Required	The range to check for repeats (for example A2:A9)
by_col	Optional	FALSE (default) compares rows. TRUE compares columns. Most beginners leave this out.
exactly_once	Optional	FALSE (default) returns every different value once. TRUE returns only values that appear exactly one time.

If the range has two or more columns, UNIQUE compares whole rows (see Example 4). With TRUE as the third argument, `=UNIQUE(A2:A9, TRUE)` returns only the values that appear exactly once.

3. Simple Example

List the unique product categories:

	A	B	C
1	Category		Unique Category
2	Electronics		Electronics
3	Furniture		Furniture
4	Electronics		Clothing
5	Clothing		Books
6	Furniture		
7	Books		
8	Clothing		
9	Electronics		

Formula in C2 only: `=UNIQUE(A2:A9)`

Excel goes down A2:A9 and keeps each category the first time it appears: Electronics, Furniture, Clothing, Books. The 8 entries become 4 unique values, spilled into C2 to C5. **Result: 4 unique categories**

4. Another Example

Remove repeated rows when two columns are checked together:

	A	B	C	D	E
1	Product	Region		Product	Region
2	Laptop	Dhaka		Laptop	Dhaka
3	Phone	Chattogram		Phone	Chattogram
4	Laptop	Dhaka		Mouse	Dhaka
5	Mouse	Dhaka		Laptop	Sylhet
6	Phone	Chattogram			
7	Laptop	Sylhet			

Formula in D2 only: `=UNIQUE(A2:B7)` (the headings in D1:E1 are typed)

Excel compares whole rows. Rows 2 and 4 match (Laptop, Dhaka) and rows 3 and 6 match (Phone, Chattogram), so each is kept once. Laptop, Sylhet is a different pair. **Result: 4 unique rows**

5. When to Use It

- Get a list of unique products, categories, or regions from a long column
- Remove duplicates from a list without changing the original data
- Find unique combinations, such as each Product and Region pair
- Find customers or items that appear only once
- Create a list that feeds a summary table

6. Important Things to Remember

- UNIQUE is a dynamic array function. You type one formula and the results spill down into the cells below.
- Results appear in the order each value first appears. The original data is not changed.
- UNIQUE is not case-sensitive ("dhaka" and "Dhaka" are the same), but extra spaces make values different.
- With two or more columns, UNIQUE compares whole rows, not single columns.
- Blank cells inside the selected range appear in the result as 0, so select only your data.
- UNIQUE is available in Excel 2021, Excel 2024, and Microsoft 365, but not in Excel 2019 or earlier.

7. Common Mistakes

- Mistake:** Selecting extra empty cells, such as A2:A12 when data ends at A9, so a 0 appears in the result. **Fix:** Select only the rows that contain data.
- Mistake:** Including the header in the range, so the header appears as one of the unique values. **Fix:** Start the range from the first data row.
- Mistake:** Seeing "duplicates" in the result, such as "Dhaka" and "Dhaka ". **Fix:** Hidden spaces cause this. Clean the data with TRIM.
- Mistake:** Getting #SPILL! because cells below the formula already contain data. **Fix:** Clear those cells or move the formula to an empty area.

8. Data Analyst Tip

Combine UNIQUE with other functions. `=COUNTA(UNIQUE(A2:A9))` counts how many different categories there are, which is 4 in the first example. `=SORT(UNIQUE(A2:A9))` gives the unique list in alphabetical order, which suits summary tables.